

GRANT, SHERMAN, AND TOTAL WAR

1864

By 1864, the war had become a grinding, exhausting struggle, but once Ulysses S. Grant was elevated to overall command of the Union's field armies in March, a coordinated strategy to defeat the Confederacy was finally at hand. In early May, over a front extending from Virginia to Georgia, Union armies marched off nearly in unison to begin the spring campaign. The major effort was in Virginia, where Grant made his headquarters and came to grips with Robert E. Lee's Army of Northern Virginia. For six weeks a series of terrible but inconclusive battles—the Wilderness, Spotsylvania, Cold Harbor—raged across the woods and fields north of Richmond. At the same time, General William T. Sherman grappled with the Confederacy's other great army, General Joseph E. Johnston's Army of Tennessee. After three months of battle and maneuver, Sherman had the Rebels backed up against the gates of Atlanta. Though Johnston was soon replaced by the aggressive General John Bell Hood, Confederate attacks around the city's perimeter were repulsed, and Atlanta fell to Sherman on September 1. Before the year ended, Hood would bleed the remnants of the Army of Tennessee dry on the battlefields of Franklin and Nashville. As summer turned to fall, while Grant slowly crushed Lee's army in the trenches at Petersburg, the other components of his grand strategy were also falling into place. Admiral David Farragut had won the contest for Mobile Bay. General Philip Sheridan had cleared Rebel forces from the Shenandoah Valley, torching the "Breadbasket of the Confederacy" along the way. Sherman would soon undertake a scorched earth campaign across Georgia, intended to break the Southern will. When Lincoln won re-election in November it was due in no small part to these victories on the battlefield. The end of the war was in sight.

